

Religion without God — Learner-v2 Source-Complete Learning Session

MASTER OVERVIEW + SOURCE MAP

How to use this companion

Syllabus scope: Philosophy of Religion. This companion visually consolidates every substantive teaching point in the learner-v2 Basic session, the complete Optional Advanced block and the consolidated register notes. Verified PYQs and original practice are retained as demand routes and answer spines; full solved-practice prose is intentionally not duplicated.

RELIGION WITHOUT GOD: FIVE ROUTES

BUDDHISM	dukkha -> path -> nirvana	no creator; no permanent self
JAINISM	jiva -> bondage -> kevala	eternal selves; no creator
MIMAMSA	Veda -> ritual -> apurva	authorless authority
SAMKHYA	prakriti -> discernment -> kaivalya	order without creator
POST-THEISM	awe / ritual / value / ultimacy	naturalism or fictionalism

Core test: does religion require a personal creator, or only ultimacy, practice, community and liberation?

STAGE 1	Test substantive and functional definitions of religion
STAGE 2	Explain Buddhism as non-creator religion
STAGE 3	Compare Jainism, Mīmāṃsā (ritual-exegesis school) and Sāṃkhya (enumeration-based dualist school)
STAGE 4	Distinguish non-theism, atheism and agnosticism
STAGE 5	Evaluate Cārvāka (materialist school)'s suprasensible critique
STAGE 6	Explain Nietzsche's post-theistic challenge
STAGE 7	Evaluate religious naturalism and fictionalism
STAGE 8	Answer the theistic denial of religion without God
STAGE 9	Apply Nyāya (logic and epistemology school)'s creator-pressure fairly
STAGE 10	Build 10/15/20-mark answers

Topic-specific visual gateway from the learner-v2 source.

COMPANION COVERAGE ARCHITECTURE

NO SUBSTANTIVE COMPRESSION

BASIC

66 source blocksDefinitions → core doctrines → thinkers → comparisons → traps

OPTIONAL ADVANCED

161 source blocksArguments → presuppositions → objections/replies → refinements

PYQ ROUTES

13 verified/original routesDemand decoding → named evidence → scoring spine

REGISTER NOTES

62 source blocksFinal retrieval sequence → traps → bounded verdict

UNIVERSAL PAPER-II ANSWER SPINE

Answer-writing master flow: DEFINE the contested term → STATE the central thesis → RECONSTRUCT the strongest argument with a named thinker/tradition → TEST the best objection → GIVE the reply or cost → COMPARE a rival route → END with a bounded verdict.

SOURCE DISCIPLINE

Source caution: quotation attributions, doxographic reports, cross-topic ownership notes and inference labels are preserved. A route map identifies where practice belongs; it is not a claim that an independent model answer is an official UPSC key.

BASIC LEARNING SESSION

CORE DEFINITIONS + DOCTRINES + THINKERS

Source-complete coverage ledger and answer-worthiness labels

[FACT] identifies retained repository doctrine or verified question data. [INFERENCE] identifies learner-facing organisation or judgement.

Canonical owner §§0–7	Basic Learning Session	Complete definition debate, Buddhism, Western critique, agnosticism, parity bench and skeletons retained
Canonical owner §§9–19	Optional Advanced	Complete Indian schools, Nietzsche, Cārvāka (materialist school), religious naturalism/fictionalism, debates, routes and source discipline retained
Audited PYQ ledger	PYQs and Answer Practice	All seven owner questions retained with exact wording and full solutions
Premium diagnostic set	MCQs / Remediation	Forty core and eight remedial questions retained with strict answer rotation
Original practice	PYQs and Answer Practice	Six non-PYQ solved models retained
Advanced dossier	Optional Advanced	Functional definition, Nyāya (logic and epistemology school) pressure, post-theism and Nietzsche refinements reconciled
Consolidated register	Final section	A–L retrieval framework retains complete answer logic

Visible learning labels. Functional/substantive definitions, Buddhism, Jainism, Mīmāṃsā (ritual-exegesis school), Sāṃkhya (enumeration-based dualist school), agnosticism and direct PYQ routes are CORE PAPER II. Boundary control, objections, comparisons and graded verdicts are CORE ANSWER. Modern religious naturalism is SUPPORTING when it clarifies, not replaces, Indian traditions. Fictionalism sincerity and Nietzschean post-theism are OPTIONAL ADVANCED.

What not to over-study. Do not let “spiritual but not religious” sociology crowd out Buddhism and Indian anti-creator systems. Do not merge atheism, agnosticism, non-theism and fictionalist participation. Master the definition test, concrete tradition, objection and exact verdict.

Learning roadmap

1	Test substantive and functional definitions of religion
2	Explain Buddhism as non-creator religion
3	Compare Jainism, Mīmāṃsā (ritual-exegesis school) and Sāṃkhya (enumeration-based dualist school)

4	Distinguish non-theism, atheism and agnosticism
5	Evaluate Cārvāka (materialist school)'s suprasensible critique
6	Explain Nietzsche's post-theistic challenge
7	Evaluate religious naturalism and fictionalism
8	Answer the theistic denial of religion without God
9	Apply Nyāya (logic and epistemology school)'s creator-pressure fairly
10	Build 10/15/20-mark answers

Contemporary scholarly anchor — [SUPPORTING]

[FACT] Fact: Recent 2025–2026 scholarship and reviews continue to discuss religious naturalism as an attempt to retain awe, value, ritual and community within a naturalistic worldview. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Inference: This strengthens the conceptual question whether supernatural belief is necessary for religion, but it does not displace the syllabus's primary evidence: Buddhism, Jainism, Mīmāṃsā (ritual-exegesis school) and Sāṃkhya (enumeration-based dualist school).

Visual gateway — define before judging

SUBSTANTIVE DEFINITION:
religion requires God, gods or supernatural beings
-> "religion without God" looks contradictory

FUNCTIONAL / DIMENSIONAL DEFINITION:
religion organises ultimacy, ritual, ethics, community, experience and liberation
-> Buddhism and Jainism clearly qualify

BOUNDARY TEST:
too narrow -> excludes recognised religions
too broad -> turns nationalism or ideology into religion

KEY VERDICT / MNEMONIC

Master verdict: A personal creator is not necessary for religion, but some disciplined orientation to ultimacy, transformation, community and soteriology is needed to prevent the category from becoming empty.

0. ONE-SCREEN MAP [INFERENCE / CAUTION]

IS GOD ESSENTIAL TO RELIGION? — NO, say these:

BUDDHISM
(non-theistic;
nirvāṇa (liberation from suffering), no
creator;
creator)

JAINISM
(no creator God;
(Comte's Religion
karma (action and moral causation) self-runs)
humanism; Marx)

MIMĀṂSĀ (ritual-exegesis school) /
SĀṂKHYA (enumeration-based dualist school) (early)
jīvas (living souls) + karma (action and moral causation))
of Humanity; ethical

SECULAR/HUMANIST
RELIGION
(no
humanism; Marx)

religion = a way of life / ethics / liberation, NOT theism

WESTERN CRITIQUES OF (theistic) RELIGION: Nietzsche ("God is dead"),
Marx ("opium"), Freud (illusion), Feuerbach (projection)

KEY VERDICT / MNEMONIC

[MNEMONIC] Mnemonic — "Religion = the 3 D's minus God: Discipline, Dharma (moral-religious duty and order), Deliverance." A religion can offer a path, ethics and liberation without a creator deity — Buddhism is the proof.

1. WHAT MAKES SOMETHING A RELIGION (if not God)? [FACT]

KEY VERDICT / MNEMONIC

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM (Recommended opening definition): Religion is a disciplined orientation to an ultimate or sacred order through doctrine, practice, community and transformation; belief in a personal creator is not a necessary condition.

- A functional definition: religion = a way of life orienting one toward ultimate meaning, liberation, and the transcendent/absolute — which need not be a personal God.
[INFERENCE / CAUTION]

- Ninian Smart's dimensions: religion has doctrinal, mythic, ethical, ritual, experiential, social & material dimensions — belief in a creator God is not on the essential list. [FACT]



- Hence "religion without God" is coherent: the sacred/ultimate ≠ necessarily a deity.

2. BUDDHISM as religion without God (2024 PYQ) [FACT]

KEY VERDICT / MNEMONIC

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Buddhism is a complete non-creator religion because dependent origination explains suffering, the path disciplines life, the Saṅgha (Buddhist monastic and practitioner community) sustains practice and nirvāṇa (liberation from suffering) supplies the final goal.

- Yet fully a religion: it has the Four Noble Truths, the Eightfold Path, ethics (śīla (ethical discipline)), meditation, the Saṅgha (Buddhist monastic and practitioner community), and a soteriology (nirvāṇa (liberation from suffering) — liberation from dukkha (suffering and unsatisfactoriness)). [FACT]

- Verdict: Buddhism decisively shows religion does not require God. [FACT]

- Non-theistic: the Buddha was silent/agnostic on a creator God (the avyākata (unanswered metaphysical questions) — unanswered questions); the world runs by praṭīyasamutpāda (dependent origination) and karma (action and moral causation), needing no creator. [FACT]

- What replaces God: the Dharma (moral-religious duty and order) (law/teaching) and the goal of nirvāṇa (liberation from suffering) — an impersonal ultimate. (Later Mahāyāna (Great Vehicle Buddhist tradition) develops quasi-devotional Buddha/Bodhisattva figures, but the core is non-theistic.) [INFERENCE / CAUTION]

**3. WESTERN CRITIQUES OF (theistic) RELIGION [INFERENCE / CAUTION]****KEY VERDICT / MNEMONIC**

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Feuerbach, Marx, Freud and Nietzsche challenge theistic religion respectively as projection, ideology, wish-fulfilment and a life-denying value-framework, but criticism of theism does not by itself construct a religion without God.

- [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Ownership note: the printed 2025 Q5(c) — "Present an account of Nietzsche's criticism of religion and morality" — is owned by Religion and Morality §9.6, because the stem couples religion with morality. The full genealogical dossier (slave revolt, ascetic ideal, Beyond Good and Evil, the criticisms and the Indian comparison) lives there. This file retains Nietzsche as a critique of theistic religion and as the bridge to post-theistic value — §9.4 — and does not duplicate the ownership.

- Freud: religion is an illusion, a wish-fulfilment / cosmic father-projection.

- Nietzsche (2025 Q5(c) — [INFERENCE / CAUTION] routed): "God is dead" — the belief in the Christian God has become unbelievable; traditional (esp. Christian) morality is a "slave morality" born of resentment, life-denying, exalting weakness. He calls for a revaluation of all values and the Übermensch who creates values without God. His critique targets religion AND its morality together. [FACT]



- Marx: religion = "the opium of the people" — a consoling illusion masking economic exploitation; it will dissolve with a just society. [FACT]



- Feuerbach: "theology is anthropology" — God is the projection of humanity's own idealised essence. [FACT]

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- These lead toward secular humanism / a "religion of humanity" (Comte) — devotion to human values without a deity (link to Sec-A Humanism).

4. AGNOSTICISM (2023 PYQ) [FACT]

KEY VERDICT / MNEMONIC

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Agnosticism suspends judgement about God's existence or knowability; unlike atheism, it withholds assent rather than asserting denial.

- Relation of religion & God for the agnostic: an agnostic may still value religion's ethical/experiential dimensions while withholding assent on God — supporting a non-theistic or minimal religiosity. [INFERENCE / CAUTION]

- Agnosticism (Huxley): the claim that the existence of God is unknown or unknowable — we should suspend judgement (distinct from atheism, which denies God). [FACT]

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- Kant's practical faith and Spencer's "Unknowable" are agnostic-adjacent positions.

5. STATEMENT / QUOTE BANK [INFERENCE / CAUTION]

1. [FACT] Nietzsche: "God is dead... and we have killed him."

3. [FACT] Feuerbach: God is the projected essence of man — "theology is anthropology."

5. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Huxley (coined "agnostic"): God's existence is unknown/unknowable.

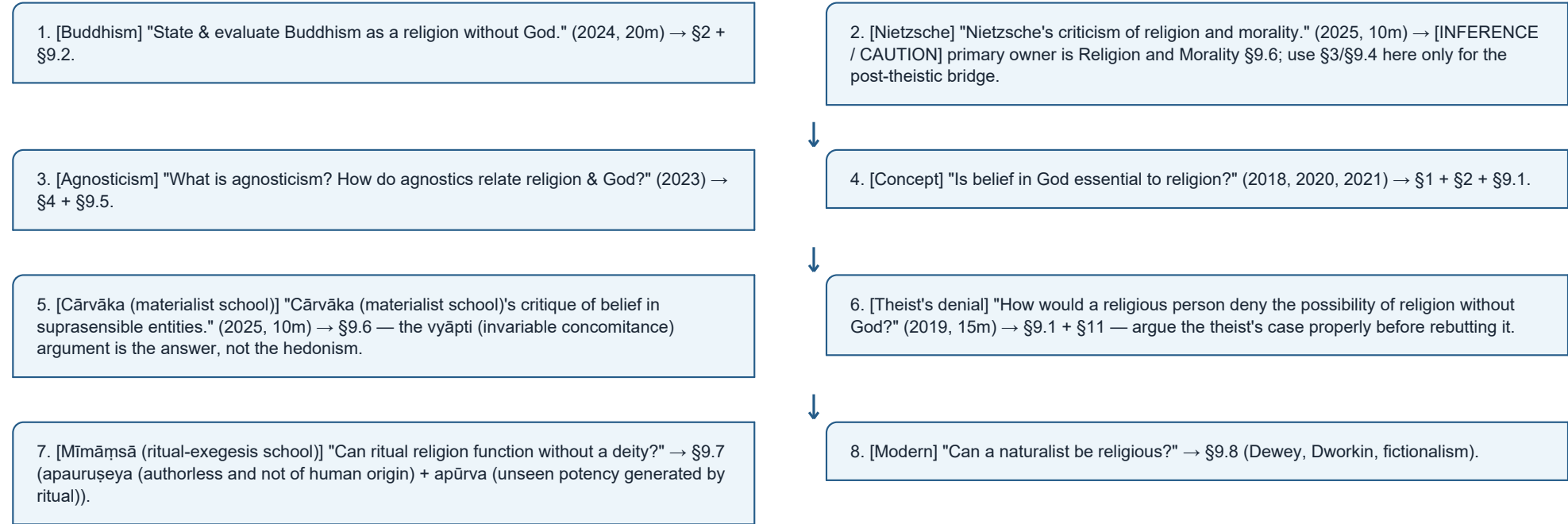
2. [FACT] Marx: religion is "the opium of the people."

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4. [FACT] Buddhist: the world runs by dependent origination — no first cause/creator needed.

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6. APPLIED-QUESTION DRILLS [INFERENCE / CAUTION]



6A. THE FIVE WAYS OF DOING WITHOUT GOD — parity bench [INFERENCE / CAUTION]

KEY VERDICT / MNEMONIC

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Non-theistic traditions replace different divine functions separately—creation, authority, moral causation, worship or salvation—so 'religion without God' names several arguments rather than one model.

Buddhism	Creator and permanent self	Pratītyasamutpāda (dependent origination), Dharma (moral-religious duty and order), Saṅgha (Buddhist monastic and practitioner community), nirvāṇa (liberation from suffering)	[FACT] Yes, fully	2024 Q7(a)
Jainism	Creator only	Karmic matter, vows, the perfected siddha (liberated perfected soul)	[FACT] Yes, fully	2018 Q5(c)

Mīmāṃsā (ritual-exegesis school)	Author of the Veda (sacred knowledge/scripture) and dispenser of fruit	Apauruṣeya (authorless and not of human origin) authority + apūrva (unseen potency generated by ritual) efficacy	[FACT] Yes — the cleanest case	2020 Q6(c)
Sāṃkhya (enumeration-based dualist school) / Yoga (disciplined spiritual practice)	Creator (Yoga (disciplined spiritual practice) keeps a non-creating Īśvara (Lord or special spiritual self))	Prakṛti (primordial material nature)'s evolution; viveka-khyāti (discriminative insight); kaivalya (liberation as isolation of consciousness)	[FACT] Yes	2021 Q5(d)
Modern naturalism / fictionalism	Supernatural ontology, or assertion itself	Nature as locus of ultimacy; practice without assertion	[INFERENCE / CAUTION] Only on a functional definition	2018 Q5(c)
Cārvāka (materialist school)	The whole supersensible order	Nothing — svabhāva (inherent nature) and this-worldly ends	? No — the limiting case	2025 Q5(a)

7. PYQ-MAPPED MODEL-ANSWER SKELETONS [INFERENCE / CAUTION]

7.1 — "State and evaluate Buddhism as a religion without God." (2024, 20m)

Intro : religion need not require a creator God (functional/Smart's dimensions).
Body : Buddhism — Buddha agnostic on creator (avyākata (unanswered metaphysical questions)); pratītyasamutpāda (dependent origination) + karma (action and moral causation) run the world;
yet 4 Noble Truths, Eightfold Path, ethics, Saṅgha (Buddhist monastic and practitioner community), nirvāṇa (liberation from suffering) = a full religion.
Assess: Dharma (moral-religious duty and order) & nirvāṇa (liberation from suffering) replace God; later devotional Mahāyāna (Great Vehicle Buddhist tradition) as a qualifier.
Concl : Buddhism proves religion-without-God is coherent and complete.

7.2 — "Nietzsche's criticism of religion and morality." (2025, 10m) — [INFERENCE / CAUTION] ROUTED

This stem couples religion WITH morality and is owned by Religion and Morality §9.6.
Use that module for the full answer (God is dead; slave revolt; resentment; ascetic ideal; revaluation; Übermensch; the criticisms and the Indian comparison).
Retain from this file only the post-theistic bridge: what value-creation looks like once the theistic horizon is withdrawn, and how that differs from Buddhist/Jain non-theism, which never had the horizon Nietzsche is mourning.

7.3 — "Discuss Cārvāka (materialist school)'s critique of the belief in the existence of suprasensible entities." (2025, 10m)

Intro : the critique is EPISTEMOLOGICAL – it is about pramāṇas, not about hedonism.

Body : (1) perception alone is a pramāṇa (means of valid knowledge); the four bhūtas exhaust reality.
 (2) the vyāpti (invariable concomitance) argument – universal concomitance cannot be known by perception (it is universal), by inference (regress/circularity), or by testimony; and upādhi (hidden limiting condition) can never be conclusively excluded, so vyabhicāra (deviation or counterinstance) remains possible.
 (3) application – God unperceived; consciousness emergent from body (dehātma-vāda (body-as-self doctrine); the madaśakti (intoxicating power)/fermentation analogy); karma (action and moral causation) and adr̥ṣṭa (unseen moral force) are props for ritual; the Veda (sacred knowledge/scripture)'s authority rejected; svabhāva-vāda (doctrine of inherent nature) explains order without a maker.

Crit : self-refutation (a universal claim about all inferences must itself be inferred); pragmatic inconsistency; Nyāya (logic and epistemology school)'s defence of vyāpti (invariable concomitance) (bhūyodarśana (repeated observation), vyabhicāra-adarśana (non-observation of a counterinstance), tarka (hypothetical reasoning)); parity – perception errs too.

Reply : the prasaṅga (reductio using an opponent's assumptions) (dialectical) reading; and the reported Purandara strand accepting laukika (ordinary empirical domain) inference while denying it for the atindriya (supersensible) – the defensible version of the thesis.

Concl : Cārvāka (materialist school) is not a godless religion but the closure of the route to any supersensible object; on its moderate reading it remains fatal to every anumāna-based natural theology.

7.4 — "How would a religious person deny the possibility of a religion without God?" (2019, 15m)

Intro : the stem asks you to ARGUE THE THEIST'S CASE first, then assess it. Do not skip step one.

Theist's case: (1) definitional – religion is relation to a personal transcendent, so "religion without God" is a category error; (2) worship requires a recipient – Jain vītarāga worship is really commemoration, not religion; (3) obligation requires a commander (divine command); (4) grace/salvation requires an agent who can give it; (5) ultimate concern without an ultimate PERSON collapses into ethics or aesthetics (the objection to Dewey and Dworkin).

Rebuttal: Smart's dimensions; Buddhism's complete soteriological structure; Mīmāṃsā (ritual-exegesis school)'s apauruṣeya (authorless and not of human origin)
 Veda (sacred knowledge/scripture) plus apūrva (unseen potency generated by ritual) (authority, efficacy and desert all secured without a deity);
 Jain siddha (liberated perfected soul) as an achieved, not a governing, divinity; the definition-by-stipulation charge.

Assess: the theist's strongest surviving point is the WORSHIP/GRACE argument, not the definition – petition and grace genuinely require a responsive God, and non-theistic religions do without them at a real cost in devotional structure.

Concl : religion without God is possible; religion without a SACRED ORDER is not.

OPTIONAL ADVANCED DEPTH

NOT REQUIRED FOR A CORE ANSWER

Advanced-dossier reconciliation — [OPTIONAL ADVANCED]

The dossier adds four bounded refinements: substantive versus functional definition; Nyāya (logic and epistemology school)'s intelligent-cause pressure against impersonal order; religious naturalism and fictionalism; and Nietzschean revaluation after the “death of God”. Use these only after concrete Buddhist, Jain or Mīmāṃsā (ritual-exegesis school) analysis. The live fictionalist question is whether one can sincerely inhabit a practice while withholding its assertions.

9. ADVANCED DOCTRINE DOSSIERS

9.1 The conceptual issue: substantive and functional religion

KEY VERDICT / MNEMONIC

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM (Recommended opening definition): A defensible cross-cultural definition treats religion as organised relation to an ultimate or sacred order, thereby including recognised non-theistic traditions without classifying every ideology as religious.

- Argument. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] If creator-belief is made necessary by definition, Buddhism is excluded by stipulation; a multidimensional account better captures doctrine, ritual, ethics, experience, narrative and institution.

- Distinction. [FACT] Non-theistic differs from atheistic: absence of a creator doctrine does not require denial of every deity or sacred being.

- Objection → reply. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Functional definitions may classify nationalism as religion. Reply: combine function with disciplined relation to an ultimate/sacred order and soteriological practice.

- Doctrine statement. [FACT] Substantive definitions identify religion by reference to gods or the sacred; functional definitions identify orientation, practice, community, meaning or liberation.



- Presupposition. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] "Religion" names a family of historically varied practices rather than one essence.



- Canonical example. [FACT] Theravāda Buddhism permits cosmological devas (celestial beings) yet denies their creatorhood and salvific ultimacy.



9.2 Buddhism

KEY VERDICT / MNEMONIC

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Dependent origination and karma (action and moral causation) make a creator explanatorily unnecessary, while ethics, meditation, community and nirvāṇa (liberation from suffering) preserve a fully religious form of life.

- Argument. [FACT] Suffering arises dependently from craving and ignorance; removing conditions removes suffering. A creator adds no explanatory or practical step to this causal-soteriological sequence.

- Distinction. [FACT] Buddha's refusal to centre speculative questions is not a blanket claim that no divine beings exist.

- Objection → reply. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Devotional Mahāyāna (Great Vehicle Buddhist tradition) appears theistic. Reply: Buddhas and bodhisattvas may perform religious functions without becoming an omnipotent creator.

- Doctrine statement. [FACT] Buddhism grounds diagnosis and liberation in Four Noble Truths, dependent origination, karma (action and moral causation) and the path, not in a creator God.

- Presupposition. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Dependent causation is explanatorily sufficient for the religious problem Buddhism addresses.

- Canonical example. [FACT] The poisoned-arrow parable prioritises removal of suffering over metaphysical delay; use it as a practical illustration, not proof of atheism.



9.3 Jainism, Mīmāṃsā (ritual-exegesis school) and Sāṃkhya (enumeration-based dualist school)

KEY VERDICT / MNEMONIC

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Jainism, Mīmāṃsā (ritual-exegesis school) and Sāṃkhya (enumeration-based dualist school) show that liberation, scripture, ritual and cosmic explanation can be organised without a creator deity.

- Argument. [FACT] Jain: an embodied creator would be limited and a perfect being lacks motive to create. Mīmāṃsā (ritual-exegesis school): a divine author is unnecessary for eternal Vedic authority. Sāṃkhya (enumeration-based dualist school): unconscious prakṛti (primordial material nature) evolves through guṇas (three constitutive qualities) in proximity to puruṣa (pure consciousness).

- Doctrine statement. [FACT] Jainism accepts perfected liberated beings but no creator; Mīmāṃsā (ritual-exegesis school) explains dharma (moral-religious duty and order) through authorless Veda (sacred knowledge/scripture) and self-fructifying ritual efficacy; classical Sāṃkhya (enumeration-based dualist school) explains cosmos through prakṛti (primordial material nature) for puruṣas (centres of pure consciousness) without a creator.

- Presupposition. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Impersonal law or dual principles can explain order and liberation.



- Distinction. [FACT] Yoga (disciplined spiritual practice)'s special puruṣa (pure consciousness) Īśvara (Lord or special spiritual self) is not straightforwardly a creator in the classical Sāṃkhya (enumeration-based dualist school) sense.

- Objection → reply. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Nyāya (logic and epistemology school) argues unconscious principles cannot organise ends. Non-theistic schools reply that observed regularity need not be modelled on artifact production.

- Canonical examples. [FACT] Karmic matter binding jīva (living soul); Vedic injunction; milk seeming to nourish the calf as an analogy for non-conscious purposiveness in Sāṃkhya (enumeration-based dualist school) discussions.

9.4 Nietzsche and post-theistic value

KEY VERDICT / MNEMONIC

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Nietzsche's 'death of God' is a diagnosis of the collapse of a value-horizon, not merely a proof of atheism; its unresolved task is the non-arbitrary revaluation of values.

- Argument. [FACT] (1) Modern truthfulness and science erode traditional belief; (2) inherited values depended on that framework; (3) their collapse creates nihilism; (4) overcoming requires revaluation and self-creation.

- Distinction. [FACT] The phrase is a cultural diagnosis, not a simple syllogistic proof that God does not exist.

- Objection → reply. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Revaluation risks elitism and arbitrary power. Nietzschean reply appeals to creative self-overcoming, though a universal normative standard remains difficult.

- Doctrine statement. [FACT] "God is dead" diagnoses the collapse of the Christian-metaphysical horizon and the resulting danger of nihilism; genealogy exposes ascetic and slave-moral valuations.

- Presupposition. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Values have genealogies tied to forms of life and can be assessed as life-enhancing or life-denying.

- Canonical example. [FACT] Ressentiment reverses aristocratic value terms and converts weakness into moral superiority.

9.5 Agnosticism and religious naturalism

KEY VERDICT / MNEMONIC

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Religious commitment may survive metaphysical uncertainty when ritual, community, reverence and transformation remain directed toward ultimacy within nature.

- Argument. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Evidence may underdetermine theism and atheism, while ethical, ritual and contemplative life can remain meaningful.

- Distinction. [FACT] Weak agnosticism ("not known") differs from strong agnosticism ("unknowable").

- Objection → reply. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] This reduces religion to ethics or aesthetics. Reply: community, ritual, transformation and orientation to ultimacy exceed ordinary morality.

- Doctrine statement. [FACT] Agnosticism suspends judgement about God's existence or knowability; religious naturalism locates ultimacy and reverence within nature rather than a supernatural person.

- Presupposition. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Religious commitment can be graded and need not include metaphysical certainty.

- Canonical example. [FACT] A person may participate in Buddhist ethical-meditative practice while withholding creator claims.



9.6 Cārvāka (materialist school): perception, the rejection of supersensible entities, and the inference problem (2025 Q5(a) owner-module)

KEY VERDICT / MNEMONIC

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Cārvāka (materialist school) attacks supersensible religion by denying that inference can establish what perception cannot check; its moderate form is strongest against inference-based natural theology. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] This is the only owner-module in the folder for Cārvāka (materialist school). Deep background: Paper I — Cārvāka (materialist school).

CONTINUATION 2/2

(bhūtacatuṣṭaya (four gross elements): earth, water, fire, air; ether is rejected as imperceptible); the puruṣārthas (goals of human life) reduce to kāma (desire) and artha (material well-being).

CONTINUATION 1/2

- Doctrine statement. [FACT] Cārvāka (materialist school) (Lokāyata (worldly materialist tradition)) holds that perception (pratyakṣa (perception)) is the only valid means of knowledge (pramāṇa (means of valid knowledge)); consequently nothing supersensible can be known, and the entities religion trades in — God, an immaterial soul, adṛṣṭa (unseen moral force)/karma (action and moral causation), heaven and hell, rebirth, apūrva (unseen potency generated by ritual), liberation and the authority of the Veda (sacred knowledge/scripture) — are all rejected as unwarranted. Reality is the four gross elements



- Argument — why only perception. [FACT] (1) A pramāṇa (means of valid knowledge) must yield certainty about its object. (2) Perception is self-evident and immediately certain. (3) Every other candidate — inference, comparison, testimony, postulation — is either reducible to perception or dependent on a general rule that perception cannot certify. (4) Therefore perception alone is a pramāṇa (means of valid knowledge), and knowledge does not extend beyond the perceptible.

- The attack on inference — the argument in full (this is the examinable core). [FACT] Inference (anumāna (inference)) depends on vyāpti (invariable concomitance), an invariable, unconditional concomitance between the mark (hetu (inferential reason), e.g. smoke) and the inferred (sādhya (probandum to be established), e.g. fire). The Cārvāka (materialist school) asks: by what means is vyāpti (invariable concomitance) itself known?

2. Not by inference: to establish this vyāpti (invariable concomitance) by another inference requires that inference's own vyāpti (invariable concomitance), generating an infinite regress or a circularity.

4. The upādhi (hidden limiting condition) problem: even repeated observation cannot rule out an unnoticed conditioning factor (upādhi (hidden limiting condition)) that makes the concomitance hold only contingently — the standard example being that fire is accompanied by smoke only when the fuel is wet. Unless every possible upādhi (hidden limiting condition) is excluded, and that exclusion is itself unverifiable, the concomitance remains merely probable (vyabhicāra (deviation or counterinstance) remains possible).

CONTINUATION 1/3

- The application to religion. [FACT] (a) God is never perceived, so the inference from world-as-effect to an intelligent maker is doubly worthless. (b) The soul is not a separate substance: consciousness is an emergent property of the body (dehātmavāda (body-as-self doctrine)) — the standard analogy is the intoxicating power (madaśakti (intoxicating power)) that arises when fermenting ingredients (kiṇva etc.) are combined, though present in none of them singly. Hence no survival, no transmigration, no liberation. (c) Karma (action and moral causation) and adṛṣṭa (unseen moral force) are imperceptible postulates invented to prop up ritual. (d) The Veda (sacred knowledge/scripture)

CONTINUATION 3/3

(doctrine of inherent nature) — things behave according to their own nature, and the sharpness of a thorn or the colour of a peacock requires no maker.

1. Not by perception: perception grasps only particular co-presences, here and now. Vyāpti (invariable concomitance) is a universal covering all cases, including unobserved past, future and remote ones — and no perception reaches those.

3. Not by testimony: testimony's authority would itself have to be established, and (for the Cārvāka (materialist school)) it is not a pramāṇa (means of valid knowledge) at all.

5. Conclusion: inference cannot deliver certainty. Where it happens to work in daily life, it works by luck or habit; and it is precisely in the supersensible domain — God, soul, karma (action and moral causation), afterlife — that no perceptual check is ever available, so there inference is worthless.

CONTINUATION 2/3

(sacred knowledge/scripture)'s authority is denied; the Cārvāka (materialist school) verses transmitted in Mādhava's Sarvadarśanasamgraha — attributed there to Bṛhaspati — mock the agnihotra, the three Vedas and ascetic practice as the livelihood of the witless. [SOURCE CAUTION] Attribution discipline: these verses survive only as quotations in the works of opponents; treat them as reported Cārvāka (materialist school) positions, not as verified primary text, and never present the popular hedonist couplet (yāvaj jīvet sukhaṃ jīvet..., "while you live, live happily; borrow and drink ghee") as anything more than a doxographic quotation. (e) Order without design: svabhāva-vāda (doctrine of inherent nature)

- The standard replies — and the Cārvāka (materialist school)'s rejoinder (both are required). [INFERENCE / CAUTION]

1. Self-refutation. The claim "inference is never valid" is itself a universal proposition about all inferences, which cannot be perceived and must therefore be inferred. The Cārvāka (materialist school)'s thesis defeats itself. — [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Rejoinder: the Cārvāka (materialist school) may present the denial dialectically, as a prasaṅga (reductio using an opponent's assumptions) (reductio) internal to the opponent's own commitments, without asserting a positive universal.

3. Nyāya (logic and epistemology school)'s positive defence of vyāpti (invariable concomitance). Concomitance is established by (i) repeated uncontradicted co-observation (bhūyodarśana (repeated observation)), (ii) non-observation of any counter-instance (vyabhicāra-adarśana (non-observation of a counterinstance)), and (iii) tarka — hypothetical reasoning that shows the denial of the concomitance leads to absurdity; Nyāya (logic and epistemology school) adds the technical device of sāmānya-lakṣaṇa-pratyāsatti (extraordinary perception of a universal) to explain how a universal can be cognitively available.

CONTINUATION 1/2

5. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] The most important nuance, and the one that separates a top script: a strand of Cārvāka (materialist school) thought — associated with the fragmentary Purandara — is reported as accepting inference for ordinary empirical matters (laukika (ordinary empirical domain)) while rejecting it as a route to the supersensible (alaukika (non-empirical domain)/atīndriya (supersensible)). On this reading the school is not committed to self-refuting global scepticism about inference; its thesis is the far more defensible one that inference cannot be extended beyond the domain in which its concomitances can be perceptually checked — which is precisely a classical Indian

CONTINUATION 1/2

- Is Cārvāka (materialist school) a "religion without God"? [INFERENCE / CAUTION] No — and saying so precisely is the mark-earning move. Cārvāka (materialist school) is not a religion at all: it has no soteriology, no sacred, no community of practice and no ultimate concern. Its place in this clause is as the limiting case at the other end: Buddhism, Jainism and Mīmāṃsā (ritual-exegesis school) show that religion can survive the loss of God; Cārvāka (materialist school) shows what happens when the epistemic route to any supersensible object is closed — you get not a godless religion but no religion at all. The contrast establishes that what non-theistic religions retain is not merely a

2. The pragmatic argument. No one, including the Cārvāka (materialist school), can eat, speak, teach or argue without relying on inference; performative consistency demands its acceptance.

4. The parity argument. Perception itself faces error (illusion, dream, defective organs) and is corrected only by further cognition — so certainty is not perception's exclusive property either; and if only indubitable sources counted, perception would fail the test too.

CONTINUATION 2/2

anticipation of the empiricist critique of metaphysics. [SOURCE CAUTION] The evidence is fragmentary and reported by opponents; present it as a reported strand, not as the school's settled position.

CONTINUATION 2/2

substitute deity but an accepted supersensible order (dharma (moral-religious duty and order), karma (action and moral causation), nirvāṇa (liberation from suffering), apūrva (unseen potency generated by ritual)) that Cārvāka (materialist school) alone rejects.

- Verdict formula. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] "Cārvāka (materialist school)'s critique succeeds exactly as far as its epistemology does. If the strong thesis is held — perception alone — it is self-refuting and pragmatically unliveable. If the moderate thesis is held — inference is admissible only where its concomitance can in principle be perceptually checked — the critique is powerful, unrefuted, and fatal to every anumāna (inference)-based natural theology, including Udayana's."



9.7 Mīmāṃsā (ritual-exegesis school): apūrva (unseen potency generated by ritual) and religion without a deity

KEY VERDICT / MNEMONIC

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Mīmāṃsā (ritual-exegesis school) is the cleanest disproof of God's necessity because apauruṣeya (authorless and not of human origin) scripture supplies authority and apūrva (unseen potency generated by ritual) links action with its delayed fruit.

- The core definition. [FACT] Jaimini's Mīmāṃsā-sūtra 1.1.2 defines dharma (moral-religious duty and order) as codanā-lakṣaṇo 'rtho dharmah — that which is characterised by (Vedic) injunction and is beneficial. Dharma (moral-religious duty and order) is thus known only from injunction, not from perception, inference or any deity's command.

CONTINUATION 2/2

(ritual-exegesis school)'s own epistemology licenses postulation to explain an otherwise inexplicable fact.

- Doctrine statement. [FACT] Pūrva-Mīmāṃsā (prior ritual-exegesis school) is the fullest case of a fully religious system with no God doing any work. The Veda (sacred knowledge/scripture) is apauruṣeya (authorless and not of human origin) — authorless, hence eternal, hence not dependent on any speaker's reliability; its injunctions (codanā (Vedic injunction)) are self-validating (svataḥ-prāmāṇya (intrinsic validity of knowledge)); and the efficacy of ritual is secured internally by apūrva (unseen potency generated by ritual).



CONTINUATION 1/2

- Apūrva (unseen potency generated by ritual) — the argument. [FACT] (1) A Vedic injunction promises a result (heaven from the jyotiṣṭoma) that does not follow immediately upon the act. (2) The act is momentary and perishes; the result comes much later, often after death. (3) A perished cause cannot produce a later effect. (4) Therefore the act must generate an unseen potency that persists until the result matures. (5) That potency is apūrva (unseen potency generated by ritual) ("the not-before", i.e. something new not previously existing). [INFERENCE / CAUTION] It is a postulate (arthāpatti (postulation from explanatory necessity)), not a perceived entity — Mīmāṃsā (ritual-exegesis school)



- The two schools' versions. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Kumārila Bhaṭṭa treats apūrva (unseen potency generated by ritual) as a potency (śakti (potency)) residing in the act or the agent, linking act to fruit. Prabhākara Miśra reframes the whole matter around niyoga (obligatory injunction)/kārya (duty that ought to be performed) — the sheer "ought-to-be-done" disclosed by the injunction, which motivates action without needing a promised fruit as its primary content. The difference matters: Prabhākara's ethics is closer to a deontology of the injunction, Kumārila's to a consequential mechanism of desert.



CONTINUATION 1/2

- Why this removes God. [FACT] (1) No author is needed for the Veda (sacred knowledge/scripture) (apauruṣeya (authorless and not of human origin)), so Udayana's vākyāt/pratyayataḥ/śruteḥ arguments have no purchase. (2) No dispenser of karmic fruit is needed, since apūrva (unseen potency generated by ritual) does that work — so the Nyāya (logic and epistemology school) karmādhyaḥśa (superintendent of karmic results) argument is answered. (3) Deities named in the mantras function as elements within the ritual structure — the dative to which the oblation is offered — not as agents who hear, choose and grant. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Kumārila's Śloka-vārttika contains sustained arguments against a

CONTINUATION 1/2

- Objection → reply. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Objection (Nyāya (logic and epistemology school)): an unconscious potency cannot select the appropriate fruit for the appropriate agent at the appropriate time; only an intelligent superintendent can. Reply: the relation is law-like, not deliberative — the objection assumes that only agents can produce determinate outcomes, which begs the question against natural law. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Second objection: how can a beginningless, authorless text have determinate meaning? Reply: meaning is carried by the eternal relation of word and referent (śabdārtha-sambandha nityatva (eternality of the word-meaning relation)), which Nyāya (logic and epistemology school)

- Verdict formula. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] "Mīmāṃsā (ritual-exegesis school) is the cleanest disproof of the claim that religion requires God. It keeps scripture, ritual, duty, merit and a soteriological goal, and replaces the deity with two devices — apauruṣeya (authorless and not of human origin) authority and apūrva (unseen potency generated by ritual) efficacy. What it thereby shows is that the religious functions God performs are separable: authority, efficacy and desert can each be secured otherwise."

CONTINUATION 2/2

creator God, including the motive problem and the impossibility of a bodiless agent acting on matter — the same family as the Jain arguments at Proofs §8.6.

CONTINUATION 2/2

denies as conventional. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Third objection: is this religion or bureaucracy? Reply: it has a sacred order, a soteriological promise, a disciplined practice and a community — which is exactly what a functional definition requires. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Note honestly that later Mīmāṃsā (ritual-exegesis school) authors drift toward theism [SOURCE CAUTION], so the atheistic reading is of the classical system.

9.8 Religious naturalism and religious fictionalism

KEY VERDICT / MNEMONIC

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Religious naturalism retains ultimacy within nature, whereas religious fictionalism retains participation without literal assent; the decisive test is whether either preserves sincere transformation rather than mere aesthetics.

- Why the module is needed. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Buddhism, Jainism and Mīmāṃsā (ritual-exegesis school) show religion without God in classical forms. The modern Western debate asks a sharper question: can someone who accepts a naturalistic ontology — or who does not believe the doctrines at all — nonetheless be religious? Two families answer yes.

- (a) Religious naturalism. [FACT] Thesis: ultimacy, reverence and the religious response are located within nature; there is no supernatural person, but nature itself sustains genuinely religious attitudes of awe, gratitude, humility and commitment.

- Julian Huxley's evolutionary humanism; Ursula Goodenough, *The Sacred Depths of Nature* (1998), on the religious response to the natural world's depth; Donald Crosby and Loyal Rue on nature as the ground of ultimacy; Spinoza is the historical ancestor via *Deus sive Natura*.

- Objection → reply. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Objection: this is aesthetics and ethics wearing religious vocabulary; nothing is worshipped, nothing saves. Reply: the naturalist replies that ultimacy, reverence, communal practice and self-transformation are all present, and that demanding a supernatural person simply restates the theistic definition.

- Positions: Don Cupitt's non-realism (*Taking Leave of God*, 1980) — God is not an objective being but the personification of the religious ideal, a "Sea of Faith" theology; Robin Le Poidevin (*Arguing for Atheism*, 1996) develops explicit religious fictionalism; Andrew Eshleman on the fictionalist's participation; Howard Wettstein on "the significance of religious experience" without metaphysical commitment.

- Objection → reply. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] (i) Insincerity/self-deception: worship presupposes belief; make-believe worship is either dishonest or hollow. Reply: immersion in a fiction is a familiar, non-deceptive human capacity (literature, ritual drama). (ii) The motivational objection: the practice's power derives from believing it true; remove that and it hollows out. Reply: fictionalists appeal to the sustained efficacy of narrative and ritual — an empirical claim that remains contested. (iii) The internal objection: believers themselves reject the description, so the account is revisionary of the very thing it purports to save.

- John Dewey, *A Common Faith* (1934): distinguishes "religion" (an institution with supernatural claims) from "the religious" (a quality of experience that unifies the self and orients it to inclusive ideal ends). Dewey proposes using "God" to denote the active relation between the ideal and the actual — not a being.

- [FACT] Ronald Dworkin, *Religion without God* (2013) — the book that literally names this clause — argues for "religious atheism": one can reject a personal God while holding that (i) human life has objective intrinsic meaning and (ii) the universe is sublime and intrinsically beautiful, and that these two value-commitments are what is religious about religion. Dworkin's move is to make value realism, not theism, the core.

- (b) Religious fictionalism. [FACT] Thesis: religious sentences are (or may be) literally false or unwarranted, yet participation in religious practice — taking the claims in a fictive, non-assertoric spirit — is rationally permissible and even valuable.

- Distinctions that matter. [FACT] Fictionalism ≠ error theory: the error theorist says the claims are false and we should stop; the fictionalist says they are not to be asserted but can be accepted within the practice. [FACT] Fictionalism ≠ non-cognitivism: the non-cognitivist says religious sentences never had truth-conditions; the fictionalist grants they do and declines to assert them. Route to Religious Language §9.4.

CONTINUATION 1/2

- Indian comparison (do not omit). [INFERENCE / CAUTION] [FACT] Advaita (non-dualism) already contains a two-level apparatus that does structurally similar work without fictionalism: *saguṇa* (with qualities) worship is genuinely efficacious at the *vyāvahārika* (empirical level of reality) level and is sublated, not exposed as fiction, at the *pāramārthika* (ultimate level of reality) level — sublation is not falsification. [FACT] Buddhism's two truths (*saṃvṛti* (conventional truth)/*paramārtha* (ultimate truth)) permit full participation in conventional religious practice while denying ultimate substantial reference. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] The comparative point that earns marks: Indian systems offer graded truth where

CONTINUATION 2/2

Western fictionalism offers pretence — the Indian device preserves the practitioner's sincerity in a way fictionalism struggles to.



- Verdict formula. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] "Naturalism and fictionalism both show that the functions of religion — reverence, community, ritual, orientation to ultimacy, self-transformation — are detachable from theistic belief. Whether what survives is still religion depends on the definition adopted at the start, which is why this clause always returns to the substantive-versus-functional question."

10. INTER-THINKER / INTER-SCHOOL DEBATES

KEY VERDICT / MNEMONIC

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The central comparison is functional: ask which divine role each school removes, what replaces it and what religious good is consequently lost or retained.

Buddhism	[FACT] Not required	Nirvāṇa (liberation from suffering)	Karma (action and moral causation)/dependent origination	Path, Saṅgha (Buddhist monastic and practitioner community), liberation
Jainism	[FACT] Rejected	Liberated jīva (living soul)/siddha (liberated perfected soul)	Karmic matter	Vows, asceticism, liberation
Mīmāṃsā (ritual-exegesis school)	[FACT] Unnecessary	Dharma (moral-religious duty and order)/heaven in classical ritual theory	Apūrva (unseen potency generated by ritual)	Vedic injunction and ritual
Sāṃkhya (enumeration-based dualist school)	[FACT] Unnecessary	Kaivalya (liberation as isolation of consciousness)	Prakṛti (primordial material nature)—puruṣa (pure consciousness) process	Discriminative liberation
Nietzsche	[FACT] Cultural belief overcome	Self-overcoming	Genealogical value creation	[SOURCE CAUTION] Critique/post-religious spirituality
Humanism	[FACT] Absent	Human flourishing	Autonomous ethics	[INFERENCE / CAUTION] Religious only under broad function
Cārvāka (materialist school)	[FACT] Rejected — and so is every supersensible entity	Kāma (desire) and artha (material well-being) in this life	? None; svabhāva (inherent nature) replaces it	? Not a religion — the limiting case that shows what non-theistic religions retain
Religious naturalism	[FACT] Absent	Ideal ends within nature (Dewey); sublime value (Dworkin)	Immanent value-realism	[INFERENCE / CAUTION] Reverence, community, ultimacy — but nothing supernatural
Religious fictionalism	[FACT] Not asserted	Whatever the practice delivers	Practice-internal	[INFERENCE / CAUTION] Participation without assertion

11. CRITICISMS AND REPLIES

KEY VERDICT / MNEMONIC

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The strongest objection is not that non-theism lacks religion by definition, but that petition, reciprocal worship and grace genuinely require a responsive personal God.

2. Hidden-God objection. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Dharma (moral-religious duty and order), nirvāṇa (liberation from suffering) or humanity merely substitutes for God. Reply: functional similarity does not establish ontological identity.

4. Nihilism objection. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Removing God removes objective value. Reply: Buddhist ethics, Jain vows and humanist normativity show alternative grounds; their objectivity still requires argument.

1. Definition objection. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Religion necessarily means relation to God. Reply: this is tradition-specific and cannot accommodate established non-theistic religions.

3. Motivation objection. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Without divine reward, religious discipline weakens. Reply: compassion, insight, karma (action and moral causation) and communal vows supply non-theistic motivation.

12. COMMON UPSC TRAPS

1. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Do not call Buddhism simply atheistic; "non-theistic" is usually more precise.

3. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Do not conflate Jain liberated beings with creator God.

5. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Distinguish agnosticism from atheism and indifference.

2. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Do not say Buddhism denies every deity.

4. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Do not present Nietzsche's "God is dead" as an empirical event or a bare atheist slogan.

6. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] A multidimensional definition should not become so broad that every ideology counts as religion.

7. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Do not call Cārvāka (materialist school) a "religion without God". It has no soteriology, no sacred and no practice; it is the limiting case that shows what non-theistic religions retain — an accepted supersensible order (dharma (moral-religious duty and order), karma (action and moral causation), nirvāṇa (liberation from suffering), apūrva (unseen potency generated by ritual)).

9. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Do not leave the self-refutation objection unanswered. Give the two replies: the prasaṅga (reductio using an opponent's assumptions) (dialectical) reading, and the reported Purandara strand accepting laukika (ordinary empirical domain) inference while denying it for the atīndriya (supersensible).

11. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Do not describe Mīmāṃsā (ritual-exegesis school)'s Veda (sacred knowledge/scripture) as "revelation". It is apauruṣeya (authorless and not of human origin) — authorless, therefore not the speech of any God.

13. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Do not merge religious naturalism (nature is the locus of ultimacy; claims are asserted) with religious fictionalism (claims are not asserted; the practice is accepted fictively) or with error theory (claims are false and should be abandoned).

8. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Do not state the Cārvāka (materialist school) position on inference without the vyāpti (invariable concomitance) problem. The argument is: concomitance cannot be established by perception (it is universal), by inference (regress/circularity) or by testimony, and upādhi (hidden limiting condition) can never be excluded.

10. [SOURCE CAUTION] Do not quote the "Bṛhaspati" verses or the hedonist couplet as primary Cārvāka (materialist school) text. They survive only in opponents' doxographies (notably Mādhava's Sarvadarśanasamgraha).

12. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Do not treat apūrva (unseen potency generated by ritual) as an observed entity. It is a postulate (arthāpatti (postulation from explanatory necessity)) introduced to explain a delayed fruit; and distinguish Kumāṛila's śakti (potency) version from Prabhākara's niyoga (obligatory injunction)/kārya (duty that ought to be performed) version.

14. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Do not present Advaita (non-dualism)'s vyāvahārika (empirical level of reality) level as fictionalism. Sublation is not falsification — the two-level device preserves the practitioner's sincerity in a way fictionalism does not.

13. KEYWORD & STATEMENT BANK

CONTINUATION 1/3

Keywords: [FACT] substantive/functional definition · family resemblance · Smart's dimensions · non-theism · atheism · agnosticism (weak/strong) · creator God · Dharma (moral-religious duty and order) · nirvāṇa (liberation from suffering) · Saṅgha (Buddhist monastic and practitioner community) · dependent origination · avyākata (unanswered metaphysical questions) · jīva (living soul) · karmic matter · pratyakṣa (perception) · anumāna (inference) · vyāpti (invariable concomitance) · hetu (inferential reason)/sādhya (probandum to be established) · upādhi (hidden limiting condition) · vyabhicāra (deviation or counterinstance) · bhūyodarśana (repeated observation) · tarka (hypothetical reasoning)

CONTINUATION 2/3

(hypothetical reasoning) · svabhāva-vāda (doctrine of inherent nature) · dehātmavāda (body-as-self doctrine) · bhūtacatuṣṭaya (four gross elements) · madaśakti (intoxicating power) analogy · laukika (ordinary empirical domain)/atīndriya (supersensible) · prasaṅga (reductio using an opponent's assumptions) · apauruṣeya (authorless and not of human origin) · codanā (Vedic injunction) · svataḥ-prāmāṇya (intrinsic validity of knowledge) · apūrva (unseen potency generated by ritual) · arthāpatti (postulation from explanatory necessity) · niyoga (obligatory injunction)/kārya (duty that ought to be performed) · prakṛti (primordial material nature)/puruṣa (pure consciousness)

CONTINUATION 3/3

(pure consciousness) · kaivalya (liberation as isolation of consciousness) · "God is dead" · nihilism · genealogy · resentment · revaluation · religious naturalism · "the religious" (Dewey) · religious atheism (Dworkin) · religious fictionalism · non-realism · error theory · two truths (saṃvṛti (conventional truth)/paramārtha (ultimate truth)) · vyāvahārika (empirical level of reality)/pāramārthika (ultimate level of reality) · sublation.

Safe formulations: [INFERENCE / CAUTION] "Creator-belief is sufficient for many religions but not necessary for religion as a cross-cultural category." · "Non-theistic religion replaces divine command with a path, causal diagnosis and soteriological goal." · "Mīmāṃsā (ritual-exegesis school) shows that the functions God performs — authority, efficacy and desert — are separable and can each be secured otherwise." · "Cārvāka (materialist school) is not a godless religion but the closure of the epistemic route to any supersensible object — which is why it ends in no religion at all."

CORPUS-DRIVEN DEPTH DELTA (expanded PYQ audit)

- [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Priority: Primary ownership is 7 of 112 parts; 2022 is the only year without an owned question.

- [FACT] Required doctrinal depth: The expanded corpus requires both positive justification of non-theistic religion and the theistic denial that religion is possible without God, plus agnosticism and Buddhism.



- ? Trap / answer consequence: Do not equate non-theistic with anti-religious or atheism with agnosticism; test function, object, soteriology, practice and ultimate concern separately.

14. PYQ ROUTING (2018–2025)

KEY VERDICT / MNEMONIC

[INFERENCE / CAUTION] Corpus signal: 7 primary-owned question-parts out of 112. The local Paper II corpus is continuous from 2018 through 2025. Cross-links do not create duplicate ownership.

2018	Q5(c)	10 marks	Can you justify religion without God? Support your answer.
2019	Q6(c)	15 marks	How would a religious person deny the possibility of a religion without God? Discuss.
2020	Q6(c)	15 marks	Critically examine the concept of God as prerequisite for a religion.
2021	Q5(d)	10 marks	Is religious life possible without the belief in God? Discuss.

2023	Q5(e)	10 marks	What is Agnosticism? How do agnostics conceptualize the relation between religion and God? Discuss.
2024	Q7(a)	20 marks	State and evaluate Buddhism as a religion without God.
2025	Q5(a)	10 marks	Discuss Cārvāka (materialist school)'s critique of the belief in the existence of suprasensible entities.

See the Philosophy of Religion PYQ Bank, 2018–2025.

15. ANSWER ARCHITECTURE (10 / 15 / 20 MARKS)

10 marks

Define non-theism/agnosticism → doctrine in four steps → distinguish nearest confusion → one objection → verdict on whether God is necessary.

15 marks

Substantive vs functional frame → one Indian case in depth → canonical example → theistic objection and reply → comparison with another school.

20 marks

Define criteria of religion → full Buddhist/Jain/Mīmāṃsā (ritual-exegesis school) case → creator critique → devotional complication → Western post-theistic comparison → graded conclusion avoiding an over-broad definition.

16. DIRECTIVE DECODER

Can you justify X? Support your answer	A defended affirmative or negative, with the criterion stated	Announce the definition of religion first; the whole answer follows from it	2018 Q5(c)

How would [an opponent] deny...? Discuss	The opponent's case, argued sympathetically, then assessed	Half the marks are in constructing the theist's argument properly	2019 Q6(c)
Critically examine the concept of X as a prerequisite for Y	Test of a necessity claim	Find one clear counter-example and defend it against reinterpretation	2020 Q6(c)
Is X possible? Discuss	A possibility claim, established by an actual case	One case done in depth beats four mentioned	2021 Q5(d)
What is X? How do X-ists conceptualise...?	A definition plus a positional account	Define, sub-divide (weak/strong agnosticism), then give the position	2023 Q5(e)
State and evaluate X as a religion without God	Both halves: the statement and the evaluation	State the doctrine fully before assessing; do not evaluate a caricature	2024 Q7(a)
Discuss X's critique of belief in Y	The argument of the critique, not its conclusions	Give the epistemology (vyāpti (invariable concomitance)), not the slogans	2025 Q5(a) Cārvāka (materialist school)

KEY VERDICT / MNEMONIC

[MNEMONIC] Rule: every question in this clause is decided by the definition of religion you adopt in the first three lines. State it, defend it briefly (substantive vs functional vs multidimensional), and then apply it consistently — inconsistency here is the commonest cause of a mediocre mark.

17. GRADED VERDICT LADDER

KEY VERDICT / MNEMONIC

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Religion does not logically require a personal creator, but it does require more than disbelief: an organised orientation to ultimacy, disciplined practice, transformation and community.

Weak (≈40%)	"Buddhism has no God but is a religion"	No definition of religion; "atheistic" used loosely
Average (≈50%)	Functional definition; Buddhism and Jainism outlined	Theist's counter-case not constructed; Mīmāṃsā (ritual-exegesis school) missing
Good (≈60%)	Definition defended; one case in depth; one objection answered	Over-broad functionalism not policed; devotional Mahāyāna (Great Vehicle Buddhist tradition) ignored

Strong (≈65–70%)	Substantive/functional dispute explicit; two Indian cases; the worship/grace objection met	Modern naturalism/fictionalism absent; Cārvāka (materialist school) misclassified
Top (≈70%+)	All the above + a discriminating distinction (non-theistic ≠ atheistic; apauruṣeya (authorless and not of human origin) ≠ revelation; sublation ≠ fictionalism; Cārvāka (materialist school) as limiting case) + the concession that petition and grace genuinely require a responsive God	—

Graded-verdict templates:

- [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Possibility stem: "Religion without God is not merely conceivable but actual: Mīmāṃsā (ritual-exegesis school) secures authority, efficacy and desert without a deity, and Buddhism supplies a complete diagnosis-and-path structure. What is not possible is religion without a sacred order — which is why Cārvāka (materialist school) ends in no religion at all."

- [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Prerequisite stem: "God is a prerequisite for some religious goods — petition, grace, covenant — but not for religion as such. The theist's strongest argument is therefore devotional, not definitional, and it should be met on that ground rather than dismissed."

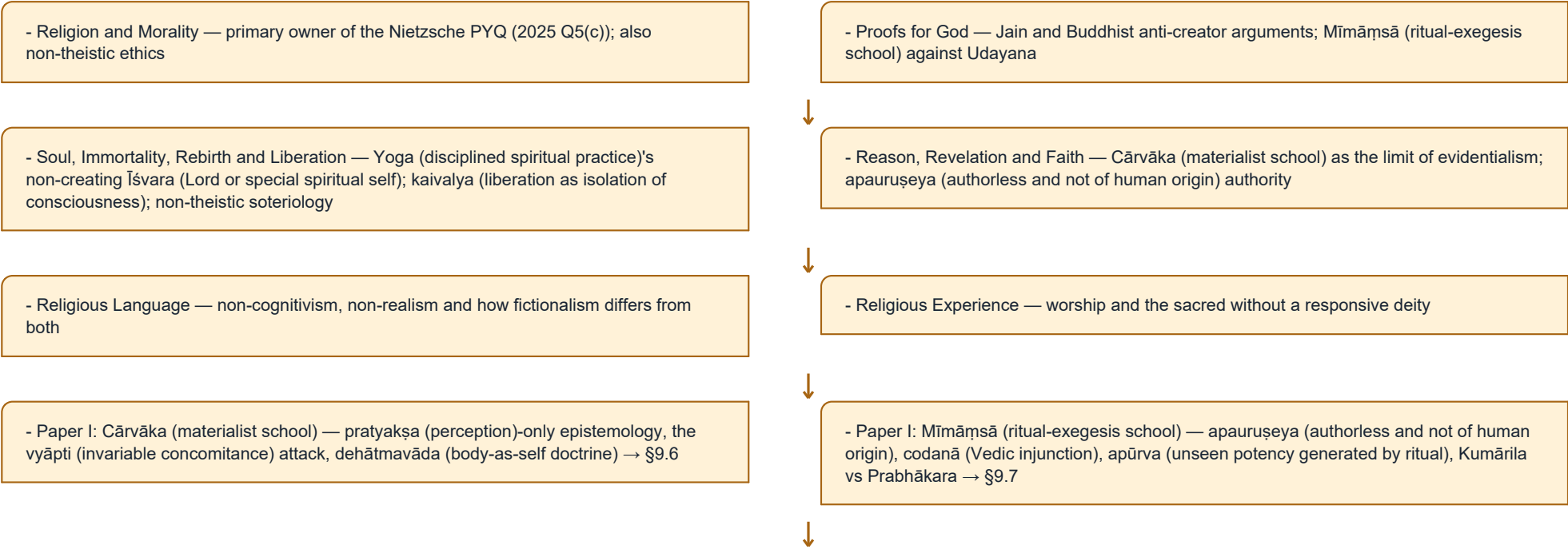
- [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Definition stem: "A definition narrow enough to exclude Buddhism is question-begging; a definition broad enough to include nationalism is empty. The workable middle requires a disciplined relation to an ultimate/sacred order together with a soteriological practice."

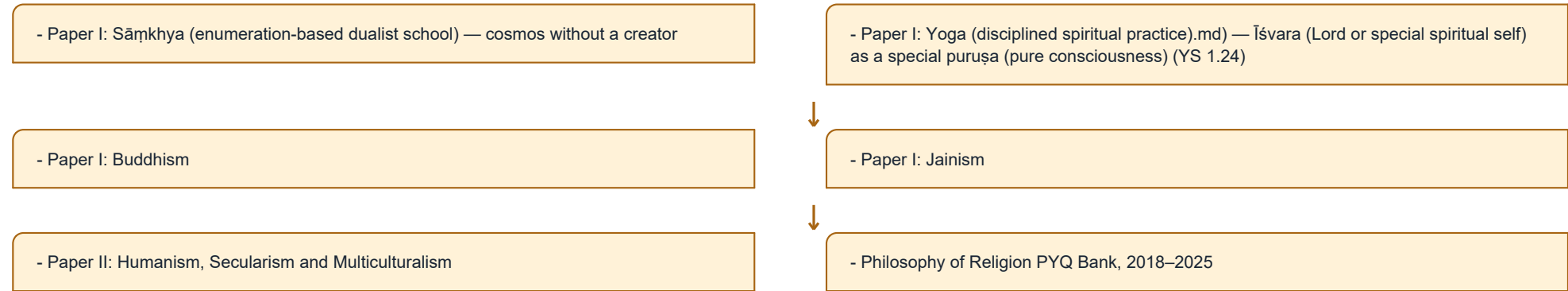
18. FACTUAL AND QUOTATION DISCIPLINE

"God is dead... we have killed him"	[FACT] Nietzsche, The Gay Science §125 (the madman); also §108 and §343	Cultural diagnosis, not an argument for atheism; full dossier in Religion and Morality
"Opium of the people"	[FACT] Marx, Introduction to A Contribution to the Critique of Hegel's Philosophy of Right (1843–44)	Quote the fuller sentence if you use it — it is more sympathetic than the slogan
"Theology is anthropology"	[FACT] Standard summary of Feuerbach, The Essence of Christianity	Projection thesis
"Agnostic"	[FACT] Coined by T. H. Huxley (1869)	Distinguish weak ("not known") from strong ("unknowable")
Smart's dimensions	[FACT] Ninian Smart's multidimensional analysis	Doctrinal, mythic, ethical, ritual, experiential, social, material
Brahmajāla/Aggañña Suttas	[FACT] DN 1 / DN 27	For the Buddhist non-creator position
Cārvāka (materialist school) verses attributed to Bṛhaspati	[SOURCE CAUTION] Preserved only in opponents' works, chiefly Mādhava's Sarvadarśanasamgraha	Report as doxographic; never as primary text
"Yāvaj jīvet sukhaṃ jīvet..."	[SOURCE CAUTION] Popular verse quoted in doxographies	Do not build the answer on it — the exam wants the epistemology

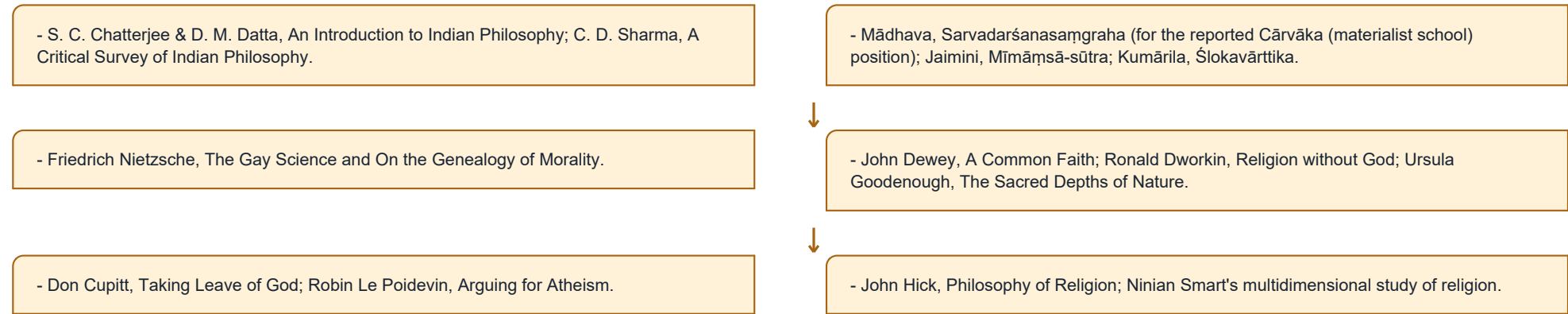
Purandara's acceptance of laukika (ordinary empirical domain) inference	[SOURCE CAUTION] Fragmentary, reported by opponents	Present as a reported strand, clearly flagged
Jaimini, Mīmāṃsā-sūtra 1.1.2 (codanā-lakṣaṇo 'rtho dharmah)	[FACT] Verified sūtra	The definition of dharma (moral-religious duty and order) by injunction
Kumārila's Śloka-vārttika against a creator	[FACT]	Same argument-family as the Jain motive/bodiless-agent arguments
A Common Faith	[FACT] John Dewey (1934)	"Religion" vs "the religious"; God as the ideal–actual relation
Religion without God	[FACT] Ronald Dworkin (2013)	"Religious atheism": objective life-meaning + the sublimity of the universe
Taking Leave of God	[FACT] Don Cupitt (1980)	Non-realism, "Sea of Faith"
Arguing for Atheism	[FACT] Robin Le Poidevin (1996)	Religious fictionalism
The Sacred Depths of Nature	[FACT] Ursula Goodenough (1998)	Religious naturalism

19. LINK-OUTS





SOURCES



PYQ ROUTES + ANSWER SPINES

FULL MODEL PROSE NOT DUPLICATED

HOW TO READ THESE ROUTES

Route discipline: question → directive/demand → named evidence → objection/reply → bounded verdict. Each card preserves the source-owned demand decoder and its explicit marks-earning criteria.

2018 · Q5(c) · 10 marks

QUESTION: Can you justify religion without God? Support your answer.

DEMAND ROUTE: “Justify” requires a defended position, not a catalogue of godless schools. Define religion first, show through actual traditions that theism is not necessary, answer the strongest theistic objection, and conclude with a qualified criterion that does not make every ideology religious.

SCORING SPINE: Opens with an explicit substantive–functional distinction and a direct thesis. • Uses Buddhism in depth, then Jainism, Mīmāṃsā (ritual-exegesis school) and Sāṃkhya (enumeration-based dualist school) as distinct evidential routes. • Distinguishes non-theism from denial of every deity. • Answers worship, morality and grace objections rather than dismissing the theist. • Prevents over-broad functionalism and correctly treats Cārvāka (materialist school) as the limiting case.

2019 · Q6(c) · 15 marks

QUESTION: How would a religious person deny the possibility of a religion without God? Discuss.

DEMAND ROUTE: Reconstruct the religious theist’s denial sympathetically before assessing it. The examiner is testing role reversal: the answer must present definitional, devotional, moral, epistemic and soteriological arguments for necessity, and only then reply through non-theistic religions.

SCORING SPINE: Obeys the unusual directive by giving the theist’s case priority and philosophical force. • Separates worship, authority, morality, cosmic order and grace arguments. • Names Nyāya (logic and epistemology school)’s intelligent superintendent and answers it through Mīmāṃsā (ritual-exegesis school). • Uses Buddhism, Jainism and Sāṃkhya (enumeration-based dualist school) without treating them as disguised theism. • Gives a graded verdict conceding what truly does require a personal God.



2020 · Q6(c) · 15 marks

QUESTION: Critically examine the concept of God as prerequisite for a religion.

DEMAND ROUTE: Test the necessity claim. Clarify which concept of God is proposed, produce counterexamples, evaluate whether they remain religious under a defensible definition, then state the limited functions for which a personal God may still be indispensable.

SCORING SPINE: Treats “prerequisite” as a necessity claim rather than merely describing non-theism. • Gives the substantive definition its strongest defence before criticizing it. • Uses three Indian counterexamples with doctrine-specific mechanisms. • Integrates modern naturalism and fictionalism without equating them with classical soteriology. • Ends with a bounded functional criterion and a nuanced necessity verdict.

2021 · Q5(d) · 10 marks

QUESTION: Is religious life possible without the belief in God? Discuss.

DEMAND ROUTE: Establish possibility through a lived religious form, not abstract definition alone. Explain what structures religious life when creator-belief is absent, distinguish non-theism from atheism, and answer whether the result is more than secular ethics.

SCORING SPINE: Proves possibility through Buddhism as an actual form of life. • Identifies doctrine, ethics, meditation, community and liberation. • Separates non-theism from atheism and secular ethics. • Adds Jain, Mīmāṃsā (ritual-exegesis school) and Sāṃkhya (enumeration-based dualist school) comparisons without losing focus. • Concedes the specific loss of petition and grace and uses Cārvāka (materialist school) as a boundary.



2023 · Q5(e) · 10 marks

QUESTION: What is Agnosticism? How do agnostics conceptualize the relation between religion and God? Discuss.

DEMAND ROUTE: The answer has two equal tasks: define and classify agnosticism, then explain how withholding knowledge-claims about God affects religious belief and practice. Distinguish it from atheism, non-theistic religion and indifference.

SCORING SPINE: Defines weak and strong agnosticism and distinguishes atheism and indifference. • Directly addresses how agnostics relate religion to God under two definitions. • Uses Huxley, Spencer and Kant with careful qualification. • Distinguishes agnostic suspension from Buddhist non-theism and naturalist reinterpretation. • Gives a graded verdict about which forms of religion can accommodate agnosticism.

2024 · Q7(a) · 20 marks

QUESTION: State and evaluate Buddhism as a religion without God.

DEMAND ROUTE: “State” requires a complete doctrinal account before criticism; “evaluate” requires testing whether Buddhism satisfies defensible criteria of religion and whether creator-belief returns in disguised or devotional form. The answer must avoid calling Buddhism a simple atheism.

SCORING SPINE: Gives the complete Buddhist diagnosis–cause–path–liberation structure before evaluation. • Explains dependent origination, karma (action and moral causation), nirvāṇa (liberation from suffering), Saṅgha (Buddhist monastic and practitioner community) and avyākata (unanswered metaphysical questions) accurately. • Distinguishes devas (celestial beings) from a creator and non-theism from dogmatic atheism. • Evaluates hidden-God, purposiveness and Mahāyāna-devotion objections with replies. • Adds precise Jain, Mīmāṃsā (ritual-exegesis school), Sāṃkhya (enumeration-based dualist school) and Cārvāka (materialist school) comparisons. • Ends with a defended definition and a graded, not absolute, verdict.



2025 · Q5(a) · 10 marks

QUESTION: Discuss Cārvāka (materialist school)’s critique of the belief in the existence of suprasensible entities.

DEMAND ROUTE: The centre is epistemology, especially the problem of establishing vyāpti (invariable concomitance). Apply that critique to God, soul, karma (action and moral causation) and scripture; then assess self-refutation and the reported moderate view of inference. Do not substitute Cārvāka (materialist school) hedonism for the requested argument.

SCORING SPINE: Makes pramāṇa (means of valid knowledge), vyāpti (invariable concomitance), upādhi (hidden limiting condition) and vyabhicāra (deviation or counterinstance) the core rather than hedonism. • Applies the argument separately to God, soul, karma (action and moral causation), scripture and cosmic order. • Includes Nyāya (logic and epistemology school)’s self-refutation and pragmatic replies. • Adds both prasaṅga (reductio using an opponent’s assumptions) and the cautiously reported Purandara qualification. • Correctly identifies Cārvāka (materialist school) as the limiting case, not a non-theistic religion.

Original 2 · 10 marks

QUESTION: Does Cārvāka (materialist school) clarify the conceptual boundary of “religion without God”? Examine.

DEMAND ROUTE: Do not repeat the 2025 critique stem. Use Cārvāka (materialist school) comparatively to identify what Buddhism, Jainism and Mīmāṃsā (ritual-exegesis school) retain after removing God, then assess whether the boundary is defensible.

SCORING SPINE: Makes a direct boundary thesis instead of reproducing the PYQ answer. • Uses vyāpti (invariable concomitance) and upādhi (hidden limiting condition) only to support the comparative point. • Specifies what three non-theistic traditions retain. • Refines the criterion to accommodate naturalism without admitting every ethics.

Original 4 · 15 marks

QUESTION: Can religious fictionalism preserve sincere participation after metaphysical belief is withdrawn? Evaluate with reference to Indian graded-truth models.

DEMAND ROUTE: Define fictionalism and distinguish it from error theory and non-cognitivism. Analyse sincerity and motivation objections, then compare rather than equate it with Advaita (non-dualism) and Buddhist two-truth frameworks.

SCORING SPINE: Defines fictionalism against two neighbouring theories. • Gives the best imaginative-participation defence and all three major objections. • Preserves the distinction between sublation, conventional truth and fiction. • Reaches a conditional verdict rather than declaring fictionalism either dishonest or complete.

Original 1 · 10 marks

QUESTION: Distinguish non-theism, atheism, agnosticism and religious naturalism. Why do these distinctions matter in the philosophy of religion?

DEMAND ROUTE: Define four positions by the different questions they answer, use examples, expose common conflation, and explain the analytical value of the distinctions.

SCORING SPINE: Defines each term through a distinct philosophical question. • Gives named Indian and Western examples. • Uses Cārvāka (materialist school) to separate atheism from non-theistic religion. • Includes an objection and a criterion-based verdict.

Original 3 · 15 marks

QUESTION: Compare Jainism and Pūrva-Mīmāṃsā (prior ritual-exegesis school) as two different strategies for sustaining religion without a creator God.

DEMAND ROUTE: Organise the answer comparatively, not as two unrelated notes. Explain ontology, authority, moral causation, practice, liberation, creator-critique and the strongest objection to each.

SCORING SPINE: Sustains comparison across ontology, authority, causation, practice and goal. • Uses jīva (living soul), karmic matter, siddha (liberated perfected soul), codanā (Vedic injunction), apauruṣeya (authorless and not of human origin) and apūrva (unseen potency generated by ritual) precisely. • Includes Nyāya (logic and epistemology school)’s intelligent-allotment objection and a non-question-begging reply. • Ends by identifying the distinct non-theistic architecture of each school.

Original 5 · 20 marks

QUESTION: Compare the Buddhist, Jain, Mīmāṃsā (ritual-exegesis school) and Sāṃkhya (enumeration-based dualist school) accounts of order and liberation without a creator. Do they reveal a common model of non-theistic religion?

DEMAND ROUTE: Give a structured four-way comparison, not parallel summaries. Identify each school’s replacement for creation, moral order and salvation; include cross-objections and finish by testing whether a common core survives doctrinal differences.

SCORING SPINE: Gives equal doctrinal depth to all four schools. • Compares mechanisms of order, bondage, practice and liberation explicitly. • Includes Yoga (disciplined spiritual practice)’s qualification and Nyāya (logic and epistemology school)’s strongest common objection. • Rejects the hidden-God claim without denying functional analogy. • Derives a carefully limited common model and a Cārvāka (materialist school) boundary.

Original 6 • 20 marks

QUESTION: Can post-theistic value, reverence and ritual remain religious without collapsing into secular ethics? Discuss with reference to Nietzsche, religious naturalism and religious fictionalism.

DEMAND ROUTE: Build the modern debate from Nietzsche’s problem of nihilism, then compare naturalist assertion with fictionalist non-assertion. Test both against the charge of being merely ethics or aesthetics, and use classical non-theistic religion as a control case.

SCORING SPINE: Uses Nietzsche to frame the nihilism problem rather than misclassifying him as a simple atheist. • Separates naturalist assertion, fictionalist non-assertion and secular ethics. • Names Dewey, Goodenough, Dworkin, Cupitt and Le Poidevin with precise roles. • Tests sincerity through Advaita (non-dualism) and Buddhist graded-truth comparisons. • Uses classical non-theistic religions as a control and gives a criterion-based final verdict.



CONSOLIDATED REGISTER NOTES

FINAL RAPID-RETRIEVAL FLOW

A. Definition control

- Substantive: identifies religion by God, gods, spirits or supernatural reality.

- Best test: avoid excluding Buddhism while preventing nationalism from automatically counting as religion.

- Functional: identifies what religion does—meaning, community, ritual, moral order and liberation.

- Dimensional: combines doctrine, practice, experience, ethics, narrative and institutions.

B. Four negative positions

Non-theism	religion does not require a creator-God
Atheism	denies or rejects God's existence
Agnosticism	suspends or denies available knowledge
Post-theism	retains or reconstructs religious value after traditional theism

C. Buddhism

- No omnipotent creator is needed.

- Dependent origination explains conditioned arising.

- Four Noble Truths and Eightfold Path supply diagnosis and cure.

- Nirvāṇa (liberation from suffering) gives a soteriological goal.

- Saṅgha (Buddhist monastic and practitioner community), ritual, ethics and experience supply religious structure.

- Devas (celestial beings), where admitted, are finite and not creators.

D. Jainism

- Eternal jīvas (living souls), no creator.

- Karmic matter binds through passion and action.

- Saṃvara (stoppage of karmic influx) and nirjarā (shedding of karmic matter) stop and remove bondage.

- Kevala (perfect knowledge) preserves perfected individuality.

- Radical ahiṃsā (non-violence) grounds ethical and communal religion.

E. Mīmāṃsā (ritual-exegesis school) and Sāṃkhya (enumeration-based dualist school)

- Mīmāṃsā (ritual-exegesis school): authorless Veda (sacred knowledge/scripture), ritual duty and apūrva (unseen potency generated by ritual) without creator speech.

- Sāṃkhya (enumeration-based dualist school): prakṛti (primordial material nature) evolves for puruṣa (pure consciousness); no creator needed.

- Yoga (disciplined spiritual practice)'s Īśvara (Lord or special spiritual self) is a special puruṣa (pure consciousness), not straightforward creator.

- Nyāya (logic and epistemology school) asks whether impersonal law can explain order and karmic allocation.

F. Cārvāka (materialist school) limit case

- Perception is primary; inference to suprasensible entities is challenged.

- Rejects soul, afterlife, karma (action and moral causation) and creator where unsupported.

- Shows that atheism may reject religious metaphysics rather than reconstruct religion.

- Trap: Cārvāka (materialist school) is not automatically a religion without God.

G. Agnosticism

- Weak: evidence is presently insufficient.

- Strong: divine reality is unknowable in principle.

- Agnostic practice is possible when ritual or ethical commitment does not require doctrinal certainty.

- Agnosticism differs from denial.

H. Nietzsche and post-theism

- "Death of God" diagnoses collapse of the inherited value-framework.

- Passive nihilism resigns; active revaluation creates new values.

- Strength: exposes dependence of morality on metaphysics.

- Cost: value creation may become arbitrary or elitist.

I. Religious naturalism and fictionalism

- Naturalism retains awe, ultimacy, ritual and ecological or ethical commitment without supernatural entities.
- Reply: community, liturgy and ultimate orientation preserve religious function.

- Fictionalism participates in religious narratives without asserting them literally.
- Residual issue: sincerity of non-assertoric participation.

- Objection: this is ethics, art or spirituality rather than religion.

J. Main objections and replies

- 1. Without God there is no transcendent object. Reply: Dharma (moral-religious duty and order), liberation, sacred order or ultimacy may organise religion.
- 4. Non-theism cannot ground objective value. Reply: traditions ground ethics in suffering, interdependence, ahimsā (non-violence) or flourishing.

2. Functionalism is too broad. Reply: require integrated ritual, community, ultimacy and transformation.

3. Impersonal karma (action and moral causation) cannot explain moral order. Reply: creator-hypothesis may add no explanatory necessity and creates its own regress.

K. Seven PYQ routes

2018: justify religion without God through definition plus Buddhist/Jain evidence. 2019: present the religious person's denial, then test substantive definition. 2020: exact owner demand—use concrete non-theistic structure and objection. 2021: exact owner demand—separate denial, suspension and non-theistic religion. 2023: agnosticism route; knowledge suspension is not atheism. 2024: Buddhism as religion without God—full 20-mark reconstruction. 2025: Cārvāka (materialist school) pressure—suprasensible entities, inference and the limit case.

L. Final answer discipline

- 1. State the definition of religion being used.
- 4. Explain its doctrine, practice, community and soteriology.
- 7. Give a bounded verdict.

- 2. Distinguish non-theism from atheism and agnosticism.
- 5. Present the strongest theistic or Nyāya (logic and epistemology school) objection.

- 3. Use at least one complete Indian tradition, not labels.
- 6. State the cost of the non-theistic model.

KEY VERDICT / MNEMONIC
Final judgement: Religion does not logically require a personal creator, but it does require more than disbelief: an organised orientation to ultimacy, practice, transformation and community.